



# Liberia



Liberia, on Africa's Atlantic coast, was founded as a republic of freed slaves. A brutal coup in 1980 and years of civil war have left gang violence and looting widespread.



## GEOGRAPHY

A coastline of beaches and mangrove swamps rises to forested plateaus and highlands inland.



## CLIMATE

High temperatures. There is only one wet season, from May to October, except in the extreme southeast.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The key social distinction used to be between Americo-Liberians – descendants of freed slaves – and the indigenous tribal peoples. However, political assimilation and intermarriage have eased tensions. Intertribal tension is now a much more serious problem, fueling the civil war which ravaged the country from 1990 to 2003.



**INSIGHT:** *Liberia is named after the people liberated from slavery who arrived from the US in the 1800s*



## THE ECONOMY

War caused economic collapse. Rubber is key export. Bans now lifted on timber and diamond exports. Revenue from merchant shipping licenses. Debt burden. Income well below prewar levels. Vast iron ore reserves.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Liberia

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1847

**CAPITAL:** Monrovia

**POPULATION:** 3.96 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 43,000 sq. miles  
(111,370 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 106 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Kpelle, Vai, Bassa, Kru, Grebo, Kissi, Gola, Loma, English\*

**RELIGIONS:** Christian 68%, traditional beliefs 18%, Muslim 14%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Indigenous tribes (16 main groups) 95%, Americo-Liberians 5%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Liberian dollar = 100 cents